

The typology of verbal person/number syncretism in Western Iranian languages

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Alexander von
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Outline

- 1 Introduction to the project
 - What is Syncretism?
 - The languages surveyed
- 2 Typology of Syncretism in Western Iranian
 - Syncretism patterns
 - Synchronic conditioning factors
 - Typological tendencies
- 3 Diachrony of Person Marking in Kurdish
 - Common-Kurdish
 - Analogy and isomorphism
 - Combating uninflectedness
 - Dialect geography and retention zones
- 4 Closing

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Definitions

- Syncretism:

		PRS		PST	
		SG	PL	SG	PL
1	<i>come</i>	<i>come</i>		<i>came</i>	<i>came</i>
2	<i>come</i>	<i>come</i>		<i>came</i>	<i>came</i>
3	<i>comes</i>	<i>come</i>		<i>came</i>	<i>came</i>

- Baerman, Brown, and Corbett (2005) systemic effects of syncretism:

- Neutralization:

		PST		SBJV	
		SG	PL	SG	PL
1	<i>was</i>	<i>were</i>	<i>were</i>	<i>were</i>	<i>were</i>
2	<i>were</i>	<i>were</i>	<i>were</i>	<i>were</i>	<i>were</i>
3	<i>was</i>	<i>were</i>	<i>were</i>	<i>were</i>	<i>were</i>

- Uninflectedness:

		PRS		PST	
		SG	PL	SG	PL
1	<i>hit</i>	<i>hit</i>	<i>hit</i>	<i>hit</i>	<i>hit</i>
2	<i>hit</i>	<i>hit</i>	<i>hit</i>	<i>hit</i>	<i>hit</i>
3	<i>hits</i>	<i>hit</i>	<i>hit</i>	<i>hit</i>	<i>hit</i>

Research Questions

- i. What are the **most frequent** syncretic patterns within Western Iranian?
- ii. What is the effect of **tense** on verbal person-number syncretism across Western Iranian?
- iii. What is the effect of **number** (singular and plural) on the diversity of syncretic patterns in the dataset?
- iv. Which **directional effects** are there in the developments of the syncretic patterns?
- v. What are the major **diachronic themes** that lead to the development of syncretism in Iranian (e.g., sound change and morphological analogy)?

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Illustrative examples

	Sari	Davani	Qohrudi	Semnan	NK Akrê	NK Mûş	NK Aşîtî
1SG	<i>-em</i>	<i>-e</i>	<i>-ûn</i>	<i>-un</i>	<i>-im</i>	<i>-im</i>	<i>-im</i>
2SG	<i>-i</i>	<i>-e</i>	<i>-e</i>	<i>-æy</i>	<i>-î</i>	<i>-î</i>	<i>-e</i>
3SG	<i>-e</i>	<i>-et</i>	<i>-e</i>	<i>-æ</i>	<i>-ît</i>	<i>-e</i>	<i>-e</i>
1PL	<i>-im</i>	<i>-u</i>	<i>-ême</i>	<i>-in</i>	<i>-în</i>	<i>-in</i>	<i>-in</i>
2PL	<i>-in</i>	<i>-i</i>	<i>-êge</i>	<i>-in</i>	<i>-in</i>	<i>-in</i>	<i>-in</i>
3PL	<i>-en</i>	<i>-en</i>	<i>-ande</i>	<i>-ăn</i>	<i>-in</i>	<i>-in</i>	<i>-in</i>

Table 1: Syncretic patterns in the present indicative—sample paradigms

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Syncretic types

Type I (6%) SG PL	Type II (3%) SG PL	Type III (1%) SG PL	Type IV (46%) SG PL	Type V (13%) SG PL	Type VI (2%) SG PL	Type VII (<1%) SG PL
1	1	1	1	1	1	1
2	2	2	2	2	2	2
3	3	3	3	3	3	3
Type VIII (1%) SG PL	Type IX (2%) SG PL	Type X (7%) SG PL	Type XI (<1%) SG PL	Type XII (<1%) SG PL	Type XIII (<1%) SG PL	Type XIV (<1%) SG PL
1	1	1	1	1	1	1
2	2	2	2	2	2	2
3	3	3	3	3	3	3
Type XV (5%) SG PL	Type XVI (5%) SG PL	Type XVII (3%) SG PL	Type XVIII (3%) SG PL	Type XIX (<1%) SG PL	Type XX (<1%) SG PL	Type XXI (<1%) SG PL
1	1	1	1	1	1	1
2	2	2	2	2	2	2
3	3	3	3	3	3	3

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Present indicative I

Type I (8%) SG PL	Type II (5%) SG PL	Type III (2%) SG PL	Type IV (37%) SG PL	Type V (12%) SG PL	Type VI (2%) SG PL	
1	1	1	1	1	1	
2	2	2	2	2	2	
3	3	3	3	3	3	
Type VIII (1%) SG PL		Type X (6%) SG PL			Type XIII (1%) SG PL	
1		1			1	
2		2			2	
3		3			3	
Type XV (13%) SG PL	Type XVI (8%) SG PL		Type XVIII (5%) SG PL	Type XIX (1%) SG PL		
1	1		1	1		
2	2		2	2		
3	3		3	3		

Past intransitive I

Type I (6%) SG PL	Type II (2%) SG PL	Type III (1%) SG PL	Type IV (52%) SG PL	Type V (17%) SG PL	Type VI (2%) SG PL	
1	1	1	1	1	1	
2	2	2	2	2	2	
3	3	3	3	3	3	
Type VIII (1%) SG PL	Type IX (1%) SG PL	Type X (6%) SG PL				
1	1	1				
2	2	2				
3	3	3				
	Type XVI (3%) SG PL	Type XVII (4%) SG PL	Type XVIII (2%) SG PL		Type XX (1%) SG PL	
	1	1	1		1	
	2	2	2		2	
	3	3	3		3	

Past intransitive II

[illegible]

Figure 2: Syncretic trends in the past intransitive

Aspectual splits

Kumzari		
	SG	PL
1	<i>-sum</i>	<i>-sim</i>
2	<i>-si</i>	<i>-sē</i>
3	<i>-sē</i>	<i>-sin</i>

Table 2: Type VII— past perfect

W Gilaki		
	SG	PL
1	<i>-im(i)</i>	<i>-im(i)</i>
2	<i>-i</i>	<i>-id(i)</i>
3	<i>-i</i>	<i>-id(i)</i>

Table 3: Type XXI — past imperfective

Gender splits

	Type X		Type XVII		
	Piran, Eğil M	Miyaro M	Siverek (F)	Palu Bingol (F)	Piran (F)
1SG	-a	-o	-a	-a	-a
2SG	-î	-î	-a	-a	-a
3SG	-Ø	-Ø	-i	-Ø	-i
1PL	-î	-î	-î	-î	-î
2PL	-î	-î	-î	-î	-î
3PL	-î	-î	-î	-î	-î

Table 4: —Gender splits in past intransitive paradigm of Zazaki

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What are the most frequent syncretic patterns?

Type I (6%) SG PL	Type II (3%) SG PL	Type III (1%) SG PL	Type IV (46%) SG PL	Type V (13%) SG PL	Type VI (2%) SG PL	Type VII (<1%) SG PL
1	1	1	1	1	1	1
2	2	2	2	2	2	2
3	3	3	3	3	3	3
Type VIII (1%) SG PL	Type IX (2%) SG PL	Type X (7%) SG PL	Type XI (<1%) SG PL	Type XII (<1%) SG PL	Type XIII (<1%) SG PL	Type XIV (<1%) SG PL
1	1	1	1	1	1	1
2	2	2	2	2	2	2
3	3	3	3	3	3	3
Type XV (5%) SG PL	Type XVI (5%) SG PL	Type XVII (3%) SG PL	Type XVIII (3%) SG PL	Type XIX (<1%) SG PL	Type XX (<1%) SG PL	Type XXI (<1%) SG PL
1	1	1	1	1	1	1
2	2	2	2	2	2	2
3	3	3	3	3	3	3

The effect of tense

	G. Zarda		CK Hewlêr		CK Kelekchi Goran	
	PRS.	PST.	PRS.	PST.	PRS.	PST.
1SG	-î	-anê	-im	-im	-im	-im
2SG	-î	-î	-î	-î	-î	-ît
3SG	-o	-Ø	-î	-Ø	-ê	-Ø
1PL	-mê	-îmê	-în	-în	-în	-man
2PL	-dê	-îdê	-in	-in	-in	-tan
3PL	-an	-î(n)	-in	-in	-in	-in

Table 5: The effect of tense on syncretism

TAM	n. paradigms	n. syncretism	%
Present indicative	182	101	55%
Past intransitive	186	94	51%

Table 6: Number of syncretic patterns per TAM category

The effect of number (singular and plural) on syncretism

- The typological literature suggests that syncretism is more common in the plural than in the singular (Baerman, Brown, and Corbett, 2005, p. 59)

Description	N	%
Syncretism only in plural	143	60%
Syncretism only in singular	21	9%
Mixed: Syncretism across singular and plural	29	12%
of which full plural vertical homophony	18	62%
Total with any plural syncretism	211	89%
Total with any singular syncretism	66	28%

Table 7: Distribution of Syncretism in Paradigms

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Common-Kurdish

*Proto-forms: Past-Intransitive

- (1) $*-m$ $*-\hat{i}$ $*-\emptyset$ $*-\hat{i}m$ $*-\hat{i}d$ $*-n$
 -1SG -2SG -3SG -1PL -2PL -3PL

+ Zagros *d*, i.e., common-Kurdish

- (2) $*-m$ $*-\hat{i}$ $*-\emptyset$ $*-\hat{i}m$ $*-\hat{i}$ $*-n$
 -1SG -2SG -3SG -1PL -2PL -3PL

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The law of Zeros

Recall that in common-Kurdish, the third-person past-tense intransitive formatives are thus (with similar juxtapositions in the rest of Iranian):
 $-\emptyset$ [-3sg] vs. $-n$ [-3pl]

Law of Zeros

Whenever a morphologically unmarked form bears cumulative exponence and shares an exponent with a marked form, the marked (non-zero) form can be reanalysed as marking the semantically marked exponent, with zero marking the shared exponent.

Two parsings

(3) $-\emptyset$ vs. $-n$ or $-\emptyset$ vs. $-\emptyset-n$
 -3SG -3PL -3(SG) -3-PL

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2SG/2PL Syncretism

- Recall that due to regular sound change, the $*\hat{i}$ [-2SG] merged with $*\hat{i}d$ [-2PL], resulting in uninflectedness $*\hat{i}$ [-2].¹
- The number distinction was restored in the second person due to analogy with the third person.

Restoration

$-\emptyset$	:	$-\emptyset-n$	::	$-\hat{i}$	:	X
-3		-3-PL		-2		2-PL

$$X = -\hat{i}-n$$

¹Note the 2SG/2PL distinction was alive and well in the past-transitive paradigm, e.g., $=t$ vs. $=tan$.

Southern Kurdish *-î-n* [-2-PL] pattern

	Sincawî 'do'	Mihran 'come'	Şêrwan K 'bring'
1SG	<i>kird-im</i>	<i>hat-im</i>	<i>hawird-im</i>
2SG	<i>kird-î</i>	<i>hat-î</i>	<i>hawird-î</i>
3SG	<i>kird-Ø</i>	<i>hat-Ø</i>	<i>hawird-Ø</i>
1PL	<i>kird-îm</i>	<i>hat-îm</i>	<i>hawird-îm</i>
2PL	<i>kird-în</i>	<i>hat-în</i>	<i>hawird-în</i>
3PL	<i>kird-in</i>	<i>hat-in</i>	<i>hawird-in</i>

1SG/1PL Syncretism

- A different type of uninflectedness occurs when a root ends with a $\hat{i}$:
 $\hat{i} \rightarrow \emptyset / \hat{i}_$
- Given this rule, $*-m$ [-1SG] merged with $*-\hat{i}m$ [-1PL] when attached to $\hat{i}$ -final roots, resulting in uninflectedness $*-\hat{i}m$ [-STEM-1].²
- The number distinction was restored in the first person due to analogy with the third person.

Restoration

$-\emptyset$	:	$-\emptyset-n$	::	$-\hat{i}m$	:	X
-3		-3-PL		-STEM-1		-STEM-1-PL

$$X = -\hat{i}m-in$$

²Note the 1SG/1PL distinction was alive and well in the past-transitive paradigm, e.g., $=m$ vs. $=man$.

Southern Kurdish $-(\hat{i})m-in$ [-1-PL] pattern

	Şêrwan K 'be'	Wermizyar 'be' 'kill'		Îlam 'come'	Qorwe
1SG	<i>bî-m</i>	<i>bî-m</i>	<i>kuşt-im</i>	<i>zanis-im</i>	<i>hat-im</i>
2SG	<i>bî-d</i>	<i>bî-t</i>	<i>kuşt-în</i>	<i>zanis-î</i>	<i>hat-îd</i>
3SG	<i>bî-Ø</i>	<i>bî-Ø</i>	<i>kuşt-Ø</i>	<i>zanis-Ø</i>	<i>hat-Ø</i>
1PL	<i>bî-min</i>	<i>bî-min</i>	<i>kuşt-îmin</i>	<i>zanis-îmin</i>	<i>hat-în³</i>
2PL	<i>bî-n</i>	<i>bî-n</i>	<i>kuşt-în</i>	<i>zanis-in</i>	<i>hat-in</i>
3PL	<i>bî-n</i>	<i>bî-n</i>	<i>kuşt-in</i>	<i>zanis-in</i>	<i>hat-in</i>

³m → Ø / nV_: *zanis-îmn=î* > *zanis-în=î* 'We knew it'

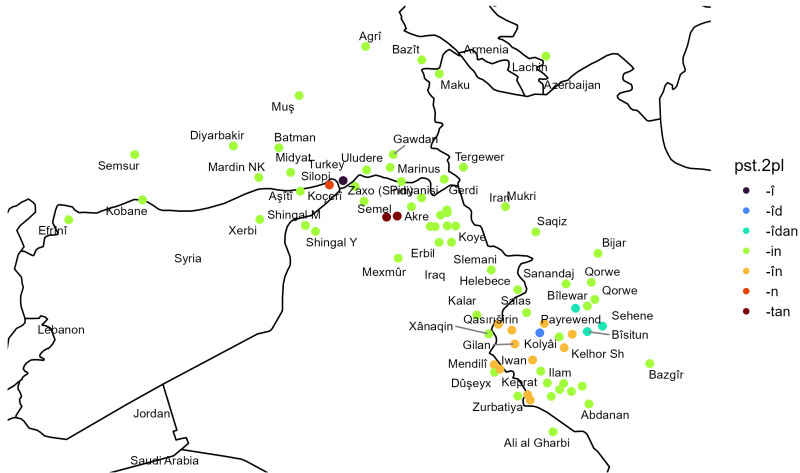
Uninflectedness in Northern Kurdish

	SK Bîlewar		CK Slêmanî		NK Mûş
	'drop'	'be'	'fall'	'not be'	'fall'
1SG	<i>da na-m</i>	<i>bü-m</i>	<i>kewt-im</i>	<i>nî-m</i>	<i>ket-im</i>
2SG	<i>da na-îd</i>	<i>bü-d</i>	<i>kewt-î</i>	<i>nî-t</i>	<i>ket-î</i>
3SG	<i>da na-Ø</i>	<i>bü-Ø</i>	<i>kewt-Ø</i>	<i>nî-ye</i>	<i>ket-Ø</i>
1PL	<i>da na-în</i>	<i>bü-n</i>	<i>kewt-în</i>	<i>nî-n</i>	<i>ket-in</i>
2PL	<i>da na-n</i>	<i>bü-n</i>	<i>kewt-in</i>	<i>nî-n</i>	<i>ket-in</i>
3PL	<i>da na-n</i>	<i>bü-n</i>	<i>kewt-in</i>	<i>nî-n</i>	<i>ket-in</i>

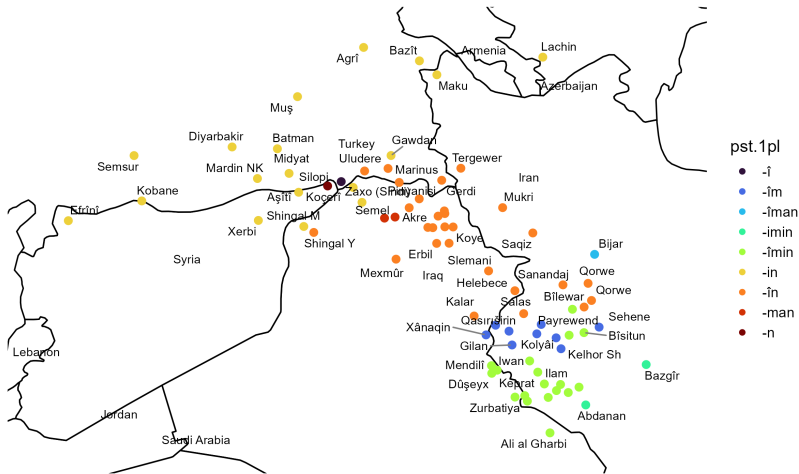
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Allomorphs of the 2PL



Allomorphs of the 1PL



Thank you

Zor supastan ekeîn!
Gelek supas!
Desta weş bo!
Fre memnûn!
Gelek menûn!
Təşəkkor!
Manana!

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